

Laying a Strong Foundation

There are five key focus areas for India as it strives for sustainable growth: women, water, technology, innovation, and entrepreneurship

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The India story has come a long way since the economic reforms of the 1990s to now being the fastest-growing large economy globally, creating economic opportunities for hundreds of millions. But as a nation, it's equally important for us to ensure that this growth story is sustainable and inclusive.

The world has only five more years in its quest to reach the 17 Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) by 2030. Interestingly, the United Nations General Assembly has proclaimed 2024–2033 as the International Decade of Sciences for Sustainable Development (IDSSD) and this should form the basis or foundation of collective action. Rooted in the 2030 Agenda, this decade seeks to harness a more effective and inclusive global approach to sustainability based on the synergistic co-operation of all sciences and all knowledge forms in an integrative and transformative way to inform policymaking and the implementation of the SDGs.

It is no secret that these challenges are linked in some way or the other to the fact that the world's production and consumption models are unsustainable. India is particularly at risk, given



BY ROSHNI NADAR MALHOTRA

THE MOMENT YOU MAKE WOMEN LEAD, WHETHER IN EDUCATION OR BUSINESS, OR TO DRIVE INNOVATION AND TECHNOLOGY, THE IMPACT BECOMES MULTI-FOLD

it is the most populous nation in the world. Plastic and electronic waste are increasingly choking our natural ecosystems.

For me, there are five key facets that would stand out for India specifically as it strives not just to meet its own SDG goals but also to embrace a future that is increasingly defined by sustainable economic development. These are, in no particular order, women, water, technology, innovation, and entrepreneurship. While each of these elements can be looked at independently, they can also have a strong and symbiotic relationship with each other.

Women are the most impacted not just by the challenges posed by climate change, but are also among the most vulnerable stakeholders in the overall social and economic development paradigm. The moment you make women the central actors, whether in education, in business, in addressing climate change or driving innovation and technology, the impact becomes manifold. Gender parity is not only a fundamental human right, but a necessary foundation for a peaceful, prosperous and sustainable world. There has been progress over the last decades, but the world is not on track to achieve gender equality by 2030. Likewise, in India, women